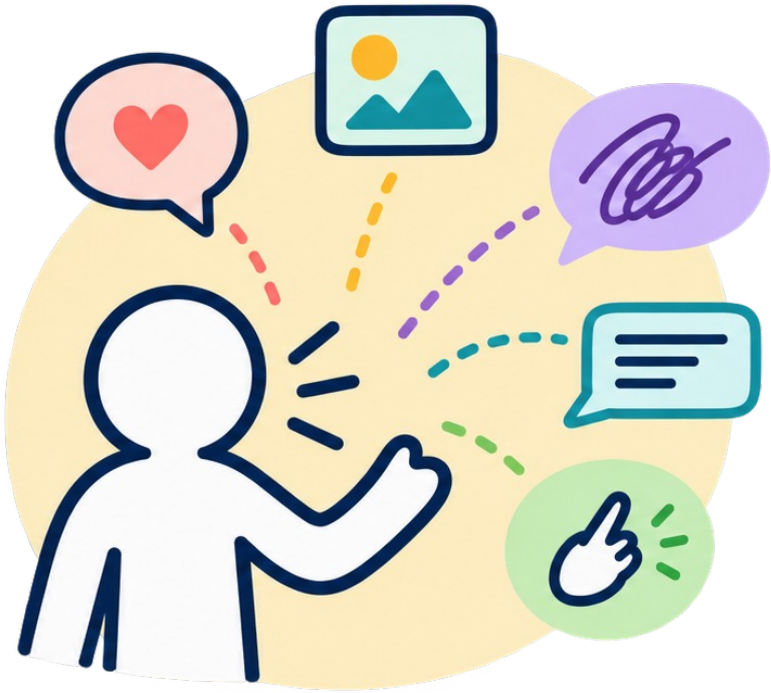




Parents and Carers · Secondary · Session 3

Understanding Autistic Experience:

**Communication,
Connection and Managing
Daily Capacity**



Communication





Understanding and expressing

How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.

Understanding

Information coming in

Spoken words



Visual or written



Demonstration



Gesture and context



Expressing

Messages going out

Speech



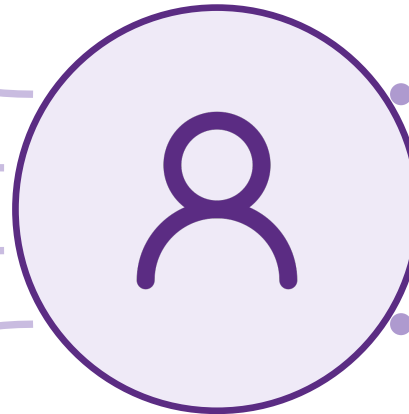
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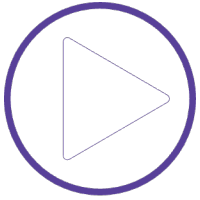


Writing or typing



Gesture, sign and movement





Communication experiences

What stood out to you about what supported communication?



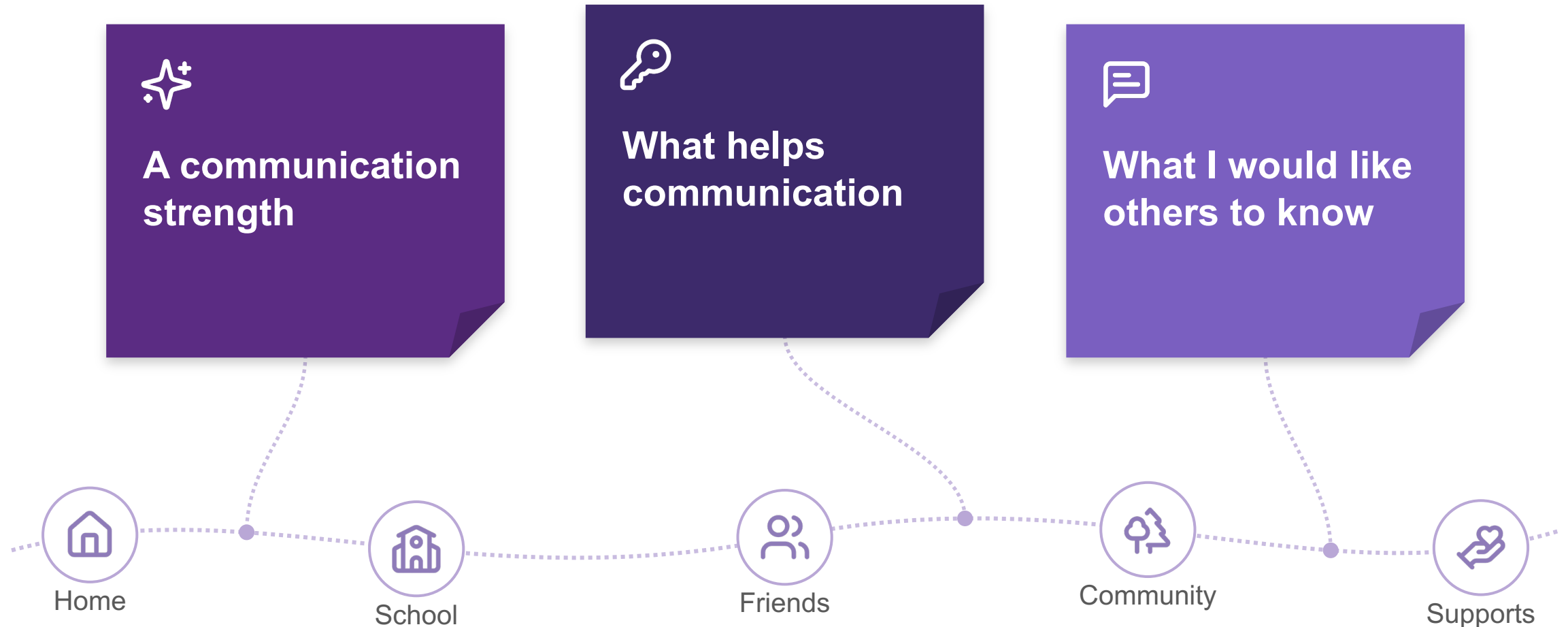
Who is part of the communication network?



Add one person or place.

You can return to the rest later.

What should travel between people and places?



How can we support communication?

1

CLEAR COMMUNICATION

Use familiar words.
One idea or step at a time.

2

PROCESSING TIME

Pause. Give time to
understand and respond.

3

VISUAL SUPPORTS

Show information as well
as saying it.

The right support depends on the person and the moment.

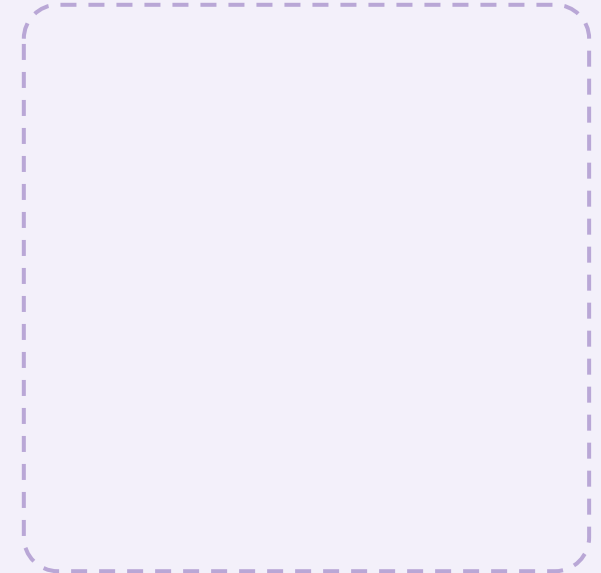
What are visual supports?



How much time is left?



What do I do next?

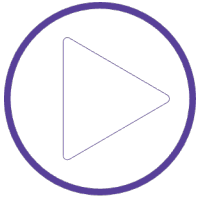


What is happening today?

Information you can see and come back to.

Double Empathy





Being social



Social Interactions

Family

School

Community

Online

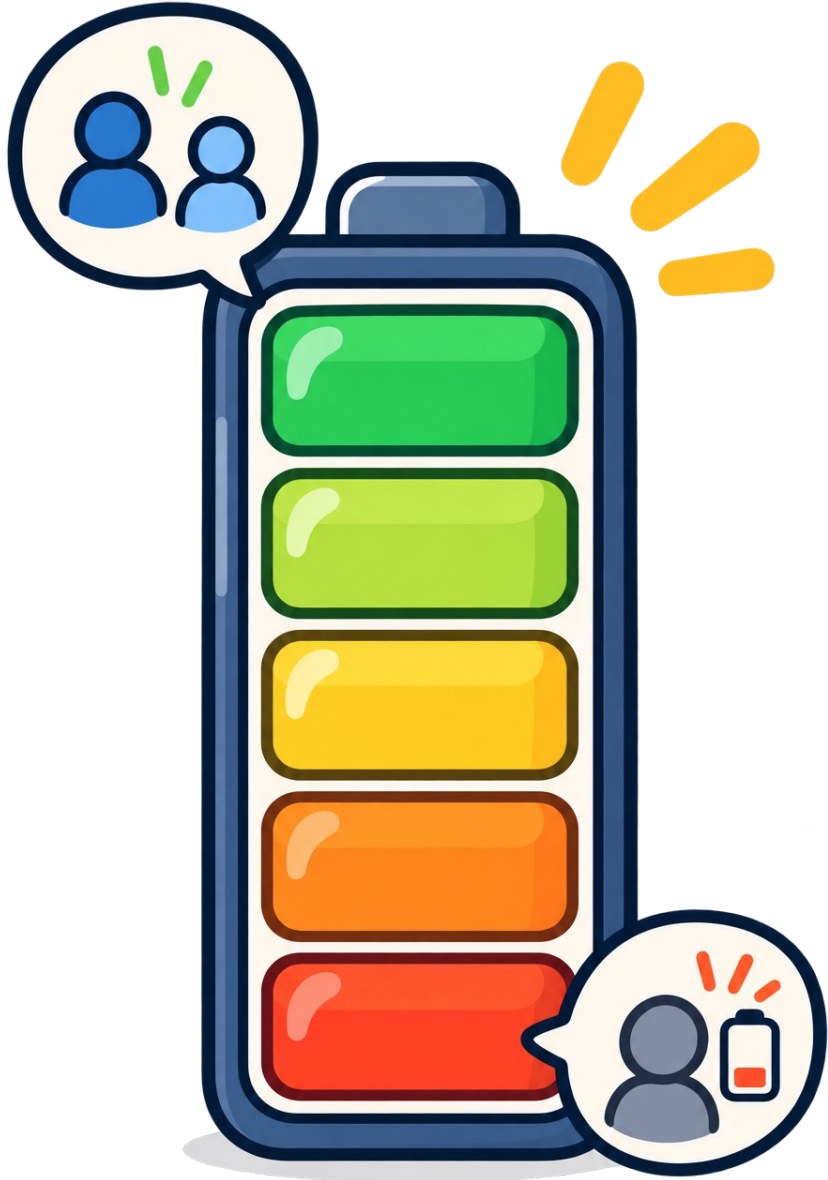


Discussion activity



- When does your young person seem most comfortable connecting with others?
- What kinds of connection do they enjoy?
(Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)
- Are there times when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?
- What can adults do to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?





Managing Daily Capacity

Batteries and Spoons

Think of your young person's energy as a battery.

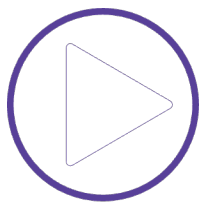
Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day.

Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, the body will show it.

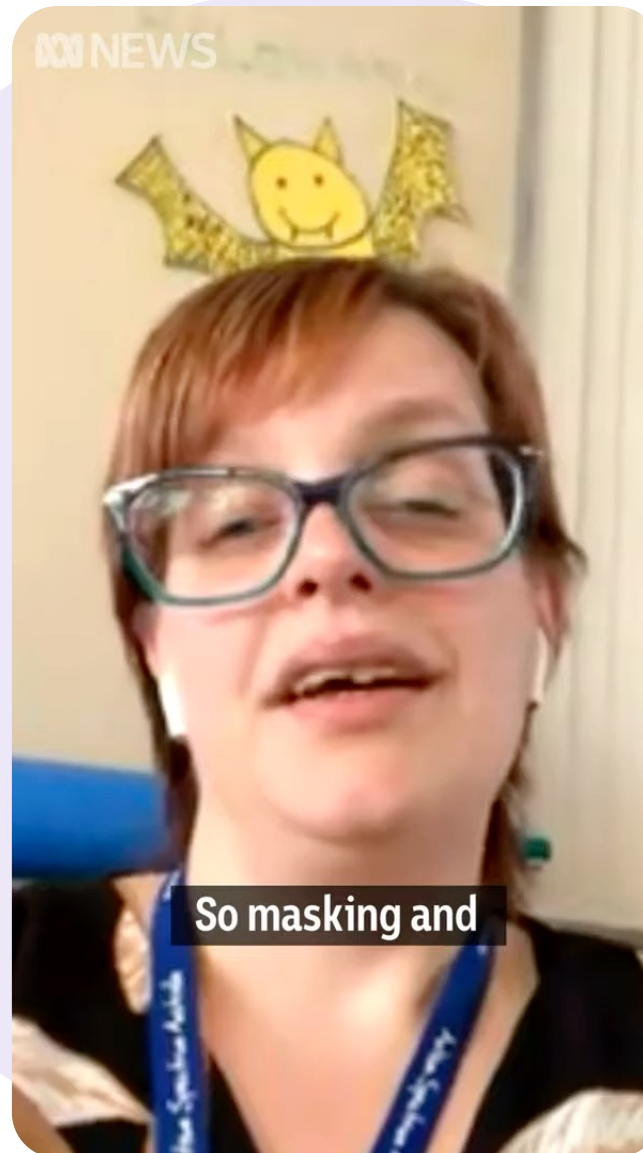


Fluctuating Capacity





Masking



Masking and the cost of appearing fine



Masking in the teenage years

The pressure to fit in is often highest in the secondary years.

Masking often increases

as fitting in with peers matters more.

Working out who you are

while hiding parts of yourself takes a lot of energy.

Burnout and School Can't

can build up over the secondary years.

A time of growth

Young people can build self-understanding and self-advocacy when school feels safe.

Feeling safe to be themselves helps young people speak up for what they need.

Discussion activity



- When does your young person seem to be working hard to appear “fine” when they are not?
- When and where do they seem most comfortable being themselves?
- What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Positive Autistic Identity

A young person who knows who they are - and feels genuinely valued for it - has more available for everything else.

